

Le Tombeau de Saint-Saens

for

**Woodwind Quintet and
Narrator**

with Poetry by Ogden Nash

and Music by Christopher Kies

(and introductory and concluding remarks by the composer)

2002/2013

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Program Note

Le Tombeau de Saint-Saens is modeled in many respects after *Le Carnaval des Animaux* by Camille Saint-Saens. In the case of the latter work, it is fascinating to note how Ogden Nash's witty poems about animals, written in the early 1950's, fit so perfectly the music that had been composed sixty-five years earlier in 1886. When I discovered, a few years ago, that Ogden Nash had written dozens of other, equally witty poems about animals, it occurred to me that a similar combination of poetry and music might be possible, but in the reverse order, using the poems as the point of departure. Quite a lot of time lapsed after this idea came to my mind before I was able to commence working on the composition. The important catalyst for me was realizing that the key to the success of *Le Carnaval* was, besides the poetry, the eclectic--one might even say plagiaristic, nature of the music itself. Once I knew that my compositional method was not to be 12 tones or whole tones, but rather *borrowed* tones, the rest was easy.

Whereas Saint-Saens quoted music by Offenbach, Berlioz, Mendelssohn, Rossini, French folk music, and even his own music (including *La Danse Macabre*), I quote in my composition the following well-known melodies:

Dies Irae; Brahms' *6th Hungarian Dance*; Chopin's C# Minor *Scherzo* and *Fantasy Impromptu*; Strauss' opening horn solo from *Till Eulenspiegel*; How Dry I Am; By the Beautiful Sea; Tea-For-Two; Gaudeamus Igitur; the Ode to Joy from Beethoven's *9th Symphony*; The Girl from Ipanema; the Swan from Saint-Saens' *Carnaval des Animaux*; Bye, Bye, Blackbird; Home Sweet Home; Christmas, Don't Be Late, as sung by the **Chipmunks**; and finally two of my own compositions, *Ducks' Ditty* (a treble chorus piece using poetry by Kenneth Grahame), and *A Brief History of Musical Time*, composed in 1996 for the **Hampshire Consort** of U.N.H.. Some of the quotes are large and obvious (e.g. the Brahms *Hungarian Dance*), but some are more difficult to detect. The listeners will hopefully forgive my attempts at rhymed commentary at both ends of the work. As Ogden Nash died in 1971, I was not able to commission him to provide me with a brilliant prelude and postlude as he had done for the Saint-Saens piece years ago.

Finally, the first version of this piece was for brass quintet and narrator in 2002. This was followed by a version for chamber orchestra in 2003, concert band in 2013, woodwind quintet in 2013 and, most recently in 2020, versions for Marimba, Clarinet in B flat and Piano, and also for Piano Four-Hands.

----Christopher Kies, 2020

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Le Tombeau de Saint-Saens

Introductory Remarks by the Composer

Narrator:

Christopher Kies was beset with sighs
When telemarketers called and asked for Mr. “Kize”.
To alleviate his frustration, he became a Klepto,
To augment this treatment, he took Bismol Pepto.
He stole from the rich, the poor, and any he could find
From among his close encounters with the classical, pop, and jazz kind.

The result was always more music, you see,
Because he really “did not know much ‘bout Geography.”
At first, *In rode Doug’s son* and best friend, *Marsha*,
So as to say, “piece, now we can startcha.”
And we’ll now end this beginning by simply saying,
“Hats off to Ogden Nash and Camille Saint-Saens
.....and musicians, START PLAYING!”

attacca Initial March

Composed in the A.D., in memory of B.C., and with special thanks to C.A.D.,
the F.D.A., C.F.C.'s, the F.H.A., D.E.S., the F.C.C., the F.A.A., all those who are A.D.D.,
the A.D.A., C.B.S., the S.G., the G.S.A., and, of course, the S.B.A.

1. The Initial March

music by Christopher Kies
11/02, arr. for WWQ 2013

♩ = 126

Flute *f* *mf*

Oboe *f* *mf*

Clarinet in B $\flat$ *f* *mf*

Horn in F *f* *mf*

Bassoon *f* *mf*

7

Fl. *f*

Ob. *f*

B $\flat$ Cl. *f*

Hn. *f*

Bsn. *f*

13

Fl. *mp* *mf*

Ob. *mp* *mf*

B $\flat$ Cl. *mf* *mf*

Hn. *mp*

Bsn. *mp*

2. The Eel

Narrator $\frac{3}{4}$ I don't mind eels $\frac{2}{4}$ Except as meals $\frac{3}{4}$

Flute $\bullet = 69$

Oboe $\frac{3}{4}$ $\frac{2}{4}$ $\frac{3}{4}$

Clarinet in B $\flat$ $\frac{3}{4}$ $\frac{2}{4}$ $\frac{3}{4}$

Horn in F $\frac{3}{4}$ $\frac{2}{4}$ $\frac{3}{4}$

Bassoon $\frac{3}{4}$ $\frac{2}{4}$ $\frac{3}{4}$

p *mp* *p* *p* *p*

3 3 3

Narr. And the way they feels

5 Doppio movimento $\bullet = 138$

Fl. $\frac{C}{4}$ $\frac{C}{4}$ $\frac{C}{4}$

Ob. $\frac{C}{4}$ $\frac{C}{4}$ $\frac{C}{4}$

B $\flat$ Cl. $\frac{C}{4}$ $\frac{C}{4}$ $\frac{C}{4}$

Hn. $\frac{C}{4}$ $\frac{C}{4}$ $\frac{C}{4}$

Bsn. $\frac{C}{4}$ $\frac{C}{4}$ $\frac{C}{4}$

mf *sfz* *mf* *p* *mp* *mp* *mp* *p* *mp*

3 3 3

in appreciation of Kenneth Grahame

3. The Duck

Narrator: Behold the duck It does not cluck.
A cluck it lacks. It quacks.
It is specially fond Of a puddle or pond.
When it dines or sups, It bottoms ups.

132 *ritard* *a tempo*

Flute *mf*

Oboe *mf* *p*

Clarinet in B $\flat$ *mf* *p*

Horn in F *mf* *p*

Bassoon *mf* *p*

6 *ritenuto* *a tempo*

Fl. *cresc.*

Ob. *cresc.* *mf*

B $\flat$ Cl. *cresc.* *mf*

Hn. *cresc.* *mf*

Bsn. *cresc.* *mf*

11

Fl. *pp* *mp* *mf* *p* *leggero*

Ob. *pp* *mp* *mf* *p* *leggero*

B $\flat$ Cl. *pp* *mp* *mf* *p* *leggero*

Hn. *pp* *mf* *mf* *espressivo*

Bsn. *p* *mf* *p* *leggero*

4. The Python

Narrator: The python has, and I fib no fibs,
318 pairs of ribs.
In stating this I place reliance
On a seance with one who died for science.
This figure is sworn to and attested;
He counted them while being digested.

Flute $\bullet = 92$ *pitch bend/ quasi gliss.* *p*

Oboe *pitch bend/ quasi gliss.* *mp*

Clarinet in B $\flat$ *p*

Horn in F *use mouth piece only gliss.* *mp*

Bassoon *p*

5

Fl. *mf* *p* *p* *mf* *p*

Ob. *f* *p* *mp* *f* *p*

B $\flat$ Cl. *flz.* *mf* *p* *p* *mf* *p*

Hn. *flz.* *mf* *p* *mp* *flz.* *mf* *p*

Bsn. *flz.* *mf* *p* *p* *flz.* *mf* *p*

9

Fl. *mf* *p* *p*

Ob. *mf* *p* *mp*

B $\flat$ Cl. *mf* *p* *p*

Hn. *f* *pitch bend/ quasi gliss.* *mp* *mp*

Bsn. *mf* *p* *p*

5. The Fly

God in His wisdom made the fly And then forgot to tell us why.

Narr. 2/4

Flute take Kazoo $\bullet = 84$ *sempre portamento e legato* *mp* *mf*

Oboe take Kazoo *mp* *mf*

Clarinet in B $\flat$

Horn in F

Bassoon

8 $\bullet = 132$

Fl. *f*

Ob. *f*

B $\flat$ Cl. *mp*

Hn. *mp*

Bsn. *mp*

15

Fl.

Ob.

B $\flat$ Cl.

Hn.

Bsn.

for Vincent Youmans and Harry Carroll

7. The Shrimp

Narr. **A shrimp** who sought his lady shrimp **Could catch** no glimpse,

Flute **84**

Oboe **p**

Clarinet in B $\flat$ **p**

Horn in F **p**

Bassoon **p**

Narr. **Not even a glimpse.** **At times,** **translucence**

Fl. **4**

Ob.

B $\flat$ Cl.

Hn.

Bsn.

Narr. **Is rather** **a nuisance.** **Allegro** **132**

Fl. **7**

Ob.

B $\flat$ Cl.

Hn.

Bsn.

f